

UX CASE STUDY

Graça Machel Trust

Women Creating Wealth Program

*Redesigning Operations for a Pan-African Women's Entrepreneurship Program: From
Fragmented Systems to a Coherent, Data-Driven Experience*

Role: Expert Consultant and Technical Coach

Organization: Graça Machel Trust - Women Creating Wealth Program

Geography: Senegal (field) - South Africa (HQ) - Pan-African scope

Duration: 2024 – 2026

Methods: Field research - User interviews - Focus groups - Service design - Data systems - KPI
dashboards

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Project Overview

Organization - Program - My Role - The Core Challenge

The Program

The Graça Machel Trust's Women Creating Wealth (WCW) program supports cohorts of African women entrepreneurs across multiple countries with coaching, business development, and access to finance. The program is designed to be transformative - equipping women with the tools, networks, and capital to scale their businesses and create economic impact in their communities. In practice, however, the operational experience - for coaches, program staff, and entrepreneurs alike - was plagued by fragmentation, redundant systems, and misaligned processes that eroded the program's potential.

Scope	Program operations · Data systems · Coaching experience · Reporting · KPI dashboards
Users	3 distinct user groups: women entrepreneurs (beneficiaries), coaches/consultants, institutional donors
Duration	September 2024 – Present (ongoing)
Key Methods	Qualitative field research - User journey mapping - Service blueprint - Systems audit - Dashboard design

The Central Problem

A Program Built to Empower - Undermined by Its Own Operations

The WCW program had excellent intent and talented people. But the operational infrastructure - data systems, reporting workflows, coaching coordination, and financing pipelines - was fragmented, constantly changing, and misaligned with how coaches and entrepreneurs actually worked. The result: coaches were buried in admin, entrepreneurs felt stuck in a loop, and the organization's ability to learn, adapt, and demonstrate impact to donors was severely compromised.

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User Research and Field Discovery

Interviews - Field Visits - Observations - Focus Groups

Research Approach

As an embedded consultant and coach within the Senegal cohort, I had privileged access to the full operational reality of the program - not just what was reported upward, but what was actually happening on the ground. My research combined:

Method	What It Revealed
In-depth interviews with entrepreneurs	Real blockers to growth beyond the program's assumptions
Observations during coaching sessions	Gap between designed experience and lived experience
Focus groups with beneficiaries	Shared patterns of frustration across the cohort
Interviews with fellow coaches	Operational pain points invisible to HQ leadership
Audit of existing data systems	4 parallel, misaligned data collection systems
Review of reporting workflows	Reporting burden consuming 30%+ of coach time

The Three User Groups

This program had three distinct user groups, each with a different experience — and different pain points:

User Group 1 Women Entrepreneurs	User Group 2 Coaches and Consultants	User Group 3 Donors and HQ Program Team
Core beneficiaries of the program	Front-line program delivery	Institutional funders + South Africa HQ
20–60 women per cohort in Senegal	Work directly with entrepreneurs	Require impact reporting and KPI data
Various sectors, stages of business	Responsible for coaching + all reporting	Define reporting formats (which keep changing)
Seek coaching, capital, and network	Experience: constant system changes, admin overload	Experience: data collected but not standardized
Experience: trained repeatedly, rarely funded		

Key Research Findings — Verbatim Themes

Finding 1 — 'The system changes every two months'

Coaches reported that the tools, templates, and platforms they used to manage the program changed approximately every 8 weeks. Each change required re-learning workflows with no training, no transition period, and no rationale communicated. The result: coaches adapted informally, creating shadow systems (personal spreadsheets, WhatsApp notes) that existed alongside the official tools — producing data duplication and inconsistency.

Finding 2 — 'They are always training us but never giving us real money'

Entrepreneurs expressed deep frustration with the program's financing pipeline. Training after training, pitch competition after pitch competition — but capital rarely reached them. The gap between 'winning' a pitch competition and receiving disbursed funds was measured in months, consumed by procurement processes, consultant recruitment, and administrative protocol. Entrepreneurs who had already proven their business model were asked, again, to prove themselves.

Finding 3 — 'We report the same thing in three different places'

Coaches maintained two separate Google Sheets (one for the Senegal team, one for the South Africa HQ), with overlapping but inconsistent fields that changed frequently as HQ requested new data points. This created a situation where coaches spent significant time on data entry for information already captured elsewhere — and where the data, scattered across systems, was effectively unusable for real-time program management.

Finding 4 — 'Weekly meetings that could be a dashboard'

Mandatory Wednesday meetings served primarily as status update sessions: which entrepreneurs had completed which modules, what their business metrics looked like, who needed follow-up. All of this information was already (in theory) captured in the data systems. The meetings existed not because the information needed a meeting — but because the systems did not make the information accessible enough to replace the meeting.

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Problem Definition

From Observations to Structured UX Problems

The 6 Core Pain Points — Mapped

Pain Point	Affected Users	UX Category
System changes every 2 months with no notice	Coaches	Change management - Information architecture
Entrepreneurs trained repeatedly but rarely funded	Entrepreneurs	Service design - Financing journey
Pitch-to-funding pipeline takes months due to procurement overhead	Entrepreneurs + Program team	Process design - Operational UX
Weekly meetings replace what a dashboard could automate	Coaches + Program team	Data UX – Decision - support systems
Duplicate reporting across 2-3 different spreadsheets	Coaches	Data architecture - Workflow design
Database fields change retroactively — past data becomes invalid	Coaches + HQ	Data governance - System design

Problem Statements

Problem Statement A — The Data Fragmentation Problem

Program coaches need a single, stable, unified data management system because the current multi-spreadsheet environment — with constantly changing fields and duplicate entry requirements — destroys data quality, wastes coach time, and makes program learning impossible.

Problem Statement B — The Financing Pipeline Problem

Women entrepreneurs who have completed training and won pitch competitions need a fast, transparent path from recognition to capital disbursement because the current procurement-heavy pipeline delays funding by months — undermining both the program's credibility and the entrepreneurs' businesses.

Problem Statement C — The Operational Visibility Problem

Program managers and coaches need real-time visibility into program metrics because the current reliance on weekly meetings and manual reporting is time-consuming, asynchronous, and does not enable adaptive decision-making.

How Might We...

- How might we design a single data system that serves both the Senegal field team and South Africa HQ — without requiring duplicate entry?
 - How might we replace the weekly status meeting with a real-time dashboard that gives coaches and managers instant program visibility?
 - How might we redesign the pitch-to-funding pipeline to eliminate procurement overhead while maintaining accountability?
 - How might we create a stable data schema that survives the program's need to evolve — without invalidating historical data?
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User Personas

Three perspectives on the same broken system

Persona 1 - Aliou, Technical Coach

ALIOU Technical Coach <i>Coaches 12 entrepreneurs Manages 2 Google Sheets + weekly reports</i>	Goals ✓ Focus on coaching, not data entry ✓ Have stable tools that don't change monthly ✓ Know instantly which entrepreneurs need follow-up ✓ Submit one report, not three Frustrations ✗ Re-learns tools every 2 months ✗ Enters same data in 2 different spreadsheets ✗ Attends a meeting to share info already in a sheet ✗ Retroactive field changes break historical records
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Persona 2 — Marème, Woman Entrepreneur

MARÈME Entrepreneur, 38 <i>Agri-processing business In the WCW program 8 months Won a pitch competition</i>	Goals ✓ Receive the funding she won 4 months ago ✓ Apply knowledge to her business, not just presentations ✓ Know clearly what happens next and when ✓ Grow her business — not attend more workshops Frustrations ✗ Won pitch — still no money months later ✗ Keeps attending trainings on topics she already knows ✗ No transparency on what happens after the pitch ✗ Feels the program is designed for reports, not for her
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Persona 3 — Sophie, HQ Program Manager (South Africa)

SOPHIE

HQ Program Manager

*Manages 5 country programs Reports to institutional donors
Needs consistent KPI data*

Goals

- ✓ Demonstrate program impact to donors with clean data
- ✓ Understand what is happening in each country in real time
- ✓ Reduce the back-and-forth with field coaches on data requests
- ✓ Build a program that learns and improves across cohorts

Frustrations

- ✗ Data from field is inconsistent and incomplete
 - ✗ Keeps requesting new fields — which disrupts field teams
- ✗ Cannot see program status without scheduling a call
- ✗ Donor reports require hours of manual data compilation

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Journey Maps

Current State — Where the Experience Breaks Down

Journey A — The Coach's Weekly Operational Experience

Mon: Coaching sessions	Tue: Update Sheet 1 (Senegal)	Wed: Update Sheet 2 (HQ)	Wed: Attend status meeting	Thu: Prepare weekly report	Fri: Respond to HQ data requests
<i>Energized</i>	<i>Frustrated — same data, different sheet</i>	<i>Exhausted — still duplicating data</i>	<i>Wasted time — info already in sheets</i>	<i>Overwhelmed</i>	<i>Confused — what data do they not have?</i>
Core value work	Unified data entry	Auto-sync with HQ	Replace with live dashboard	Auto-generated from data	Self-serve HQ data access

Row 1: Journey Step **Row 2:** Emotional State **Row 3:** Design Opportunity

Journey B — The Entrepreneur's Pitch-to-Funding Experience

1. Attends training	2. Submits pitch	3. Pitch competition	4. Wins!	5. Waits...	6. Procurement process	7. More training
<i>Hopeful</i>	<i>Motivated</i>	<i>Excited</i>	<i>Euphoric</i>	<i>Anxious</i>	<i>Confused</i>	<i>Demoralized</i>
Relevant content	Clear criteria	Transparent process	Celebrate the win	Clear timeline	Fast-track disbursement	Cash, not training

The Most Damaging UX Moment

Step 4 to Step 5: The transition from 'winning' to 'waiting' is the most damaging moment in the entire program experience. An entrepreneur who has just demonstrated her capability to a panel of judges and been publicly recognized enters a black-box procurement process with no timeline, no communication, and no certainty. This moment — more than any other — destroys trust and motivation. It is a critical UX failure that has nothing to do with design and everything to do with process.

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Design Solutions

What I Designed and Implemented — and the Reasoning Behind Each Decision

Solution 1 — Unified Program Data Management System

I designed and deployed a unified data management system to replace the fragmented dual-spreadsheet environment. The core design principle: one source of truth, accessible to all stakeholders, stable enough to support longitudinal tracking.

Design Decision	Why It Matters
Single master database replaces 2 Google Sheets	Eliminates duplicate entry — data entered once, used everywhere
Role-based views: Field team sees relevant columns; HQ sees their view	Both teams see what they need without overwhelming either with irrelevant data
Locked core schema — new fields added as columns, never replacing old ones	Historical data never becomes invalid — critical for longitudinal impact measurement
Auto-calculated impact indicators (jobs created, revenue growth)	Coaches stop computing manually; system surfaces insights automatically
Version-controlled field definitions — coaches can see what changed and when	Transparency reduces confusion and builds trust in the system

Solution 2 — KPI Dashboard for Real-Time Program Visibility

I designed a KPI dashboard to replace the weekly Wednesday status meeting for routine program monitoring. The dashboard surfaces — in real time — the metrics that previously required a meeting to share.

Dashboard Design Philosophy

The dashboard was designed around a key insight from research: the Wednesday meeting existed because the data was invisible, not because the conversation required a meeting. By making data visible in real time, we free the meeting for what meetings are actually for: decisions, exceptions, and relationship-building. Routine status updates belong in a dashboard. Strategic conversations belong in a meeting.

Dashboard Modules Designed

- Cohort Overview: total entrepreneurs enrolled, active, completed, dropped off — by country and sector
- Coaching Progress Tracker: each entrepreneur's coaching session completion rate, flagged if behind schedule
- Business Metrics Panel: revenue trends, employment numbers, business stage progression across the cohort
 - Financing Pipeline: pitch applications submitted, winners announced, funds disbursed, disbursement timeline
- Donor Reporting Export: one-click report generation in donor-required formats — eliminating manual compilation

Solution 3 — Adaptive Learning Framework for Program Management

I implemented a data-driven adaptive learning approach that allowed the program to adjust coaching interventions in real time based on field data — rather than waiting for end-of-cycle evaluations.

Before: Static Program Delivery	After: Adaptive Learning System
Curriculum fixed at program start	Data signals trigger curriculum adjustments mid-cycle
Adjustments made only between cohorts	Coaches flag barriers; system aggregates patterns
Coaches identify issues anecdotally	Field insights surface to HQ in real time
HQ learns what worked 6 months later	Program can pivot within a cohort if data shows a pattern
Donors receive a report — not a learning cycle	Donors see a live learning system, not a static report

Solution 4 - Redesigned Pitch-to-Funding Pipeline

Based on research findings, I developed recommendations for a streamlined pitch-to-funding process designed to dramatically reduce the time between 'winner announced' and 'funds disbursed'.

Current Pipeline (Broken)	Redesigned Pipeline
1. Pitch competition held	1. Pre-qualified consultant pool ready before pitch
2. Winners announced	2. Winners announced + fast-track agreement signed same day
3. Procurement process opened to recruit consultants	3. Individualized support plan (not generic training)
4. Consultants recruited and contracted	4. Milestone-based disbursement: 30% now, 70% on delivery
5. Training program designed	—
6. Training delivered	—
7. Fund disbursement initiated	—

Total: 4–8 months from win to money	Target: 3–4 weeks from win to first disbursement
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Solution 5 - Business Plan Evaluation Framework

I designed a structured, multi-criteria business plan evaluation framework for the program's pitch competition — replacing ad hoc assessment with a rigorous, transparent, and reproducible process.

Evaluation Pillar	Key Criteria	Why It's UX
Economic Viability	Revenue model, cost structure, break-even timeline, financial projections	Transparent criteria = fairer experience for entrepreneurs
Employment Creation Potential	Current employees, projected hires with funding, quality of jobs created	Measurable outcomes = credible reporting for donors
Social Impact and Scalability	Community reach, women empowerment dimension, replicability	Scalability focus = program impact beyond individual beneficiaries

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07

Masterclass Design for African Women Entrepreneurs

UX Applied to Learning Experience Design

Beyond data systems and operations, I designed and facilitated a series of masterclasses for program beneficiaries. Designing a learning experience for diverse entrepreneurs is a UX challenge: the 'user' is adult, time-poor, contextually specific, and comes with existing knowledge that must be honored.

Masterclass Topics Designed

Masterclass	Design Approach
Growth Strategy for African Businesses	Case studies from comparable African markets — not Silicon Valley
Business Model Innovation	Canvas-based workshop: participants redesign their own model live
Market Access and Distribution	Concrete buyer identification exercise + outreach script
Access to Finance — Demystified	Walk-through of real application processes; peer success stories
User-Centered Design for Entrepreneurs	UX thinking applied to their own product/service — who is my user?

UX Principle Applied to Learning Design

The most common failure in training programs for entrepreneurs is designing for the educator, not the learner. I applied a core UX principle: the 'user' of the masterclass is the entrepreneur in her context — limited time, immediate business pressures, variable literacy, and a low tolerance for abstract theory. Every masterclass was designed to deliver one immediately actionable tool or decision the entrepreneur could apply that week. Concepts were translated into templates, frameworks, and scripts — not slides.

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Reflection

What This Project Taught Me About UX at Organizational Scale

Learning 1 - The most impactful UX problems are invisible from the outside

The fragmentation at Graça Machel Trust was not visible in the program's brochures, annual reports, or pitch decks. It was only visible from inside — from the field, from the coaches, from the entrepreneurs themselves. This is why embedded research matters: no amount of desk research would have revealed the Wednesday meeting problem, the retroactive field-change problem, or the depth of the pitch-to-funding frustration. The most valuable UX research tool I had was being in the room.

Learning 2 - Data systems are user experiences

UX is typically associated with apps, screens, and digital interfaces. This project reinforced that a Google Sheet is a user interface. A reporting workflow is a user journey. A data entry form that changes every two months is a usability disaster. The UX principles of consistency, feedback, and minimal friction apply equally to operational systems as they do to consumer apps. Treating data systems as UX problems - not just IT problems - is the insight that unlocked the solutions here.

Learning 3 - Serving multiple user groups requires explicit prioritization

This project had three user groups with genuinely competing needs: coaches wanted stability, HQ wanted new data, and entrepreneurs wanted capital - not more training. A UX designer's job in this context is not to make everyone happy simultaneously - it is to make the prioritization explicit and design for the primary user first. In this case, the entrepreneurs were the program's primary users — and every operational decision should be evaluated against the question: 'Does this serve or burden the entrepreneur we are here to support?'

What I Would Do Differently

- Conduct a formal service blueprint workshop with HQ leadership earlier - to align on user group prioritization before designing solutions
- Prototype the unified data system in a smaller pilot cohort first - before full deployment, to catch schema issues earlier
- Establish a 'change freeze' policy for the data schema - no field modifications during an active cohort cycle
- Co-design the pitch evaluation framework with past cohort entrepreneurs - not just program staff and donors